

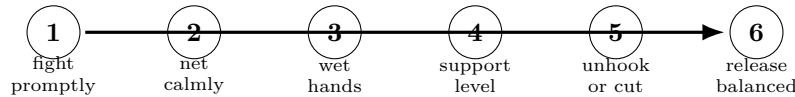
Handling & Release

ChatGPT edition

Prepare before the bite

Build the release station

Match tackle to the largest plausible fish. Open pliers and cutters; wet and stage a knotless rubber net; set the camera before casting. Decide whether the fish can remain beside the boat.



Before-cast check

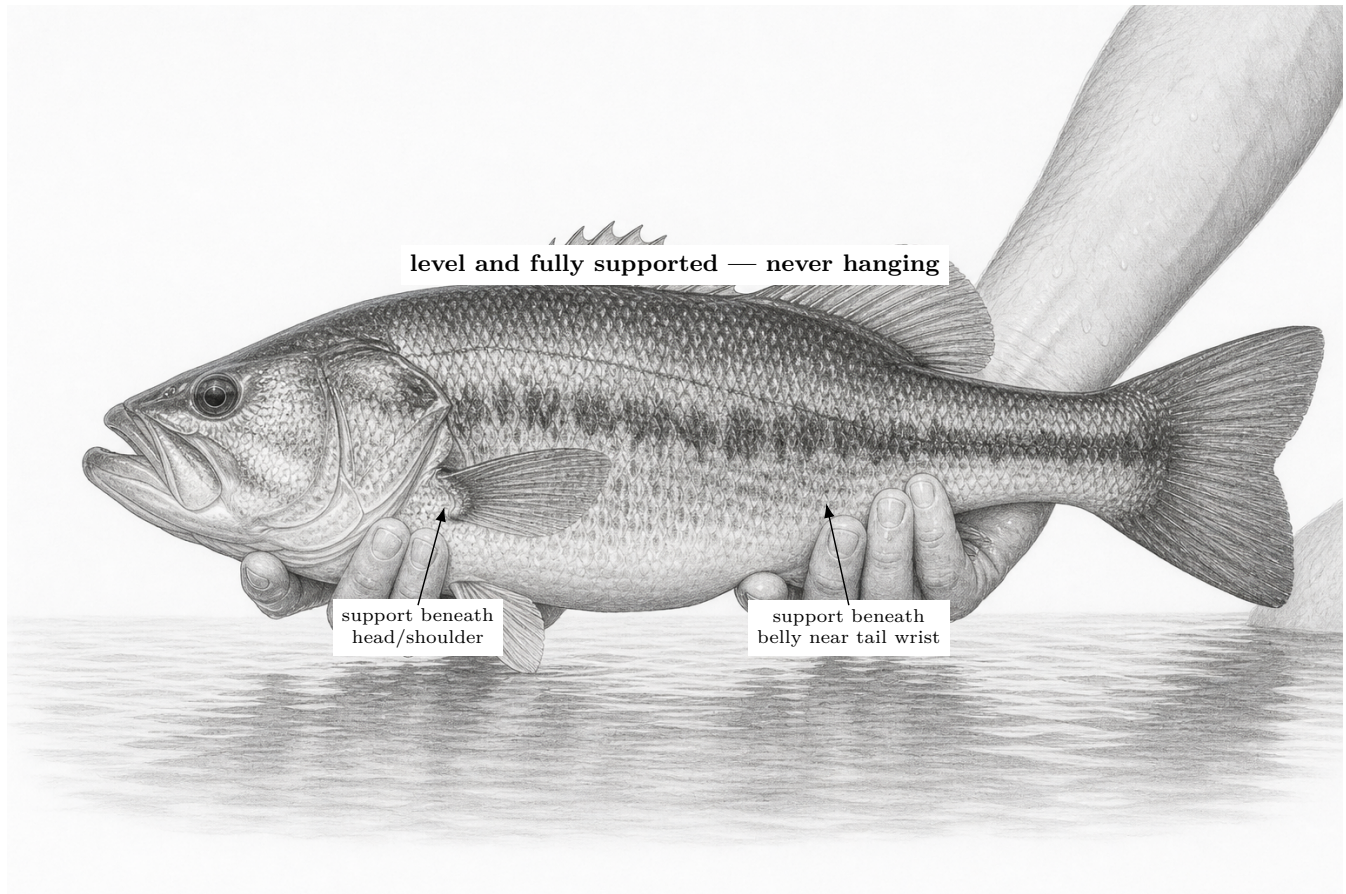
Pliers open one-handed; cutters sever the actual leader; net is untangled and wet; measuring board is ready; camera is awake. If release is likely, favor tackle that limits deep hooking.

At the fish: decide at each gate

1. **Control.** Use steady pressure and adequate tackle. If the fish still surges, keep it in water; do not drag it onto a dry floor.
2. **Net or boatside?** Net only when it reduces handling. Guide the fish headfirst; never chase its tail with the hoop.
3. **Hook access?** Back out an exposed hook with the fish supported. If deep extraction is slow or destructive, cut the line promptly.
4. **Photo?** Only if camera and hands are ready. Lift horizontally, close to the water, then return it without delay.
5. **Release.** Support upright in water. Let go when it holds balance and swims under its own power; face gentle current only when one exists.

Ask mid-process: Is the next action for the fish, or for the picture? Has air exposure stopped being brief? Would cutting now cause less injury?

Support map



Avoid	Observable correction
Dry hands / dry deck	Skin remains glossy and wet; fish touches wet net or wet hands, not carpet or clothing.
Vertical jaw hold	Second hand carries body weight; spine stays nearly level.
Gill contact	Fingers remain outside gill plate and away from eyes.
Repeated measuring	Use a hard-stop board once; release immediately if short.
Violent “reviving”	Hold balanced without pumping. Movement is self-directed.

Troubleshooting the release

Observation	Response
Fish rolls on its side	Keep supported upright in water; reduce handling. If legal harvest is not an option, give it quiet time rather than pumping.
Hook will not reverse	Expose only what is necessary; cut hook or line with staged cutters instead of tearing tissue.
Fish repeatedly caught deep	Change target depth, location, tackle, or species; do not keep proving the same harm.
Warm fish fights poorly	Shorten the fight and air time; consider ending or changing the trip before another capture.

DEPTH AND TEMPERATURE

Deep capture and warm water increase risk. Wisconsin DNR does not recommend artificial swim-bladder deflation. Change location, depth, tackle, or target rather than repeatedly producing fish unlikely to survive.

Release verified: the fish remains upright without hand pressure, shows coordinated fin movement, and leaves under its own power. Source: Wisconsin DNR Catch-and-Release Guidelines.

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